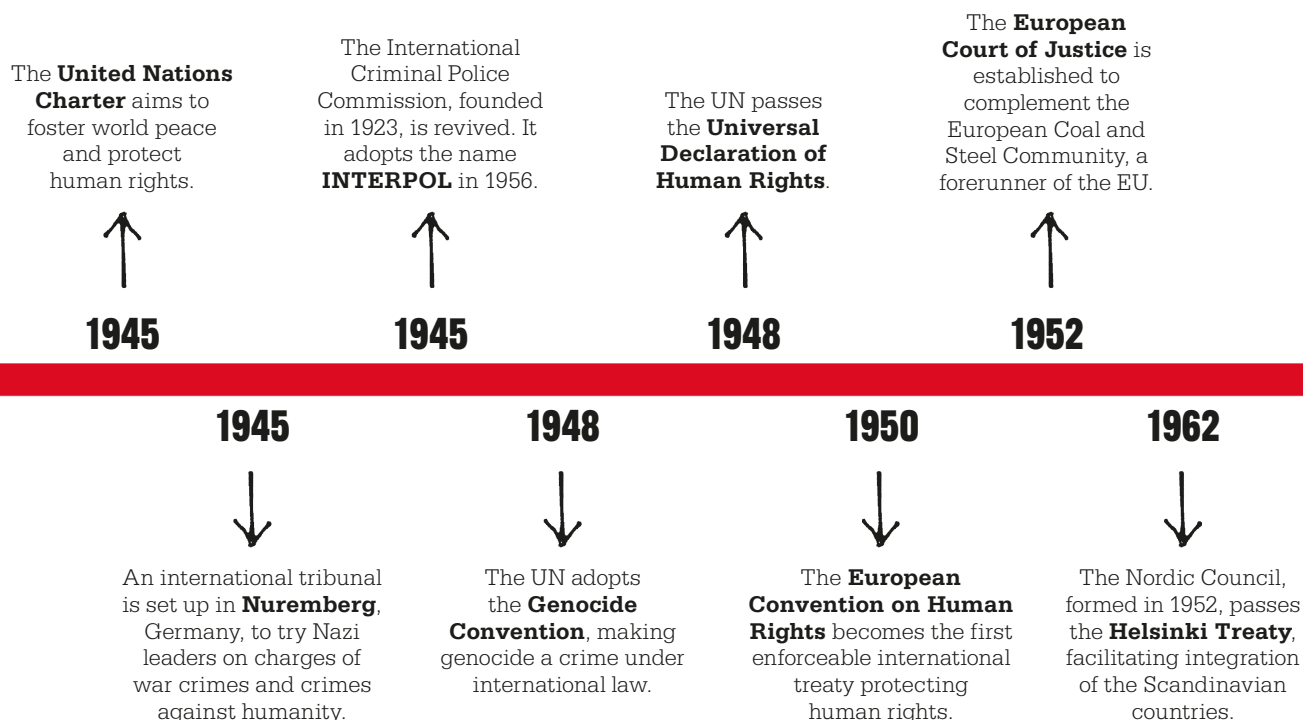




The decades following World War II saw a dramatic change in the global political landscape and in attitudes toward international cooperation. Two devastating global conflicts separated by less than a generation had created an unprecedented desire for peace and justice, and the horrors of the Nazi Holocaust underlined the need for international legislation. However, it wasn't long before the opposing ideologies of East and West began to cast the long shadow of the "Cold War," made more menacing by the threat of nuclear weapons.

Although attempts had been made after World War I to set up truly international organizations, such as the League of Nations, these had ultimately failed in the turbulent economic and political

atmosphere that saw both the global Great Depression and the rise of the Nazis in Germany. Toward the end of World War II, however, international leaders were more open to the idea of such an organization, and the United Nations was founded in October 1945.

Retribution and institutions

In the immediate aftermath of the war, the huge scale of the Nazi atrocities, especially the Holocaust, prompted a strong international response, which came first in the form of a series of military tribunals to try the surviving German military and political leaders. These trials were held in Nuremberg in 1945–1946, with a panel of judges from the US, UK, Soviet Union (USSR), and France. They were the first international military tribunals

of their kind, and they defined three new types of crime: crimes against peace, including starting an unprovoked war; war crimes, such as breaking the international rules of war as set out in the Hague Conventions of 1899 and 1907; and crimes against humanity, including mass murder, forced labor, and religious persecution.

The UN recognized genocide as a crime in 1946 and outlawed it in 1948, the same year that it codified a general statement of its objectives in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Within a few years, the UN had brought together the world's major powers in numerous international agencies.

In Europe, which had suffered heavily from the ravages of both world wars, there was a widespread desire for peaceful cooperation,